

EPISODE ONE CHALLENGERS — EXECUTION UNDER AQ-NAR-PROMPT-EP1-CHALLENGERS v2.0

Execution ID: EX-2026-08-24-01 · **Date:** 2026-08-24 · **Model and mode:** Claude Opus 5, extended reasoning, web research available · **Influence brief:** [SAS/true-crime-genre-anatomy.md](#)

PART ONE — SOURCE AND ATTRITION REPORT

1.1 Authorities

Read in order: [pivot-brief-2026-08-23.md](#) (including the 2026-08-24 clock convention and all-party consent rulings), [critical-reviewer-charter.md](#), [episode-1-vo-lock-v1.1-WIP.md](#), [ally-quinn-bible.md](#) (including new §2.3.1), [canon-character-roster.md](#), [portrait-prompts-canon-cast.md](#).

Excluded and not used: the Episode One pitch pack; [art-kit-items-and-ui](#); [item-icon-regeneration-kit](#); [stage-backgrounds-ep1-kit](#). Incumbent knowledge limited to the one-paragraph summaries and the occupied-territory list.

Additional influence, at Stephen's direction: the genre anatomy document, whose Part Four generation brief was applied as a preference layer above the prompt's own requirements. Its governing finding shaped the whole seed field: **the canon runs on live injustice rather than live chase**, and the reconstructive engines (unreliable record, institutional failure) are the ones a merge board is actually built for.

1.2 Seed field

Field one: twenty-six seeds. No second field was required.

Rejected at stage one without research: nine. Grounds were occupied territory (three), retired engine or reskin of it (two), coincidence-led (two), decoratively Havenbay (one), child-harm-led (one).

Rejected at Kill Gate Zero: fourteen. **Three survived to falsification and all three survived it.** Attrition therefore ran 26 to 17 to 3.

1.3 The five closest rejected seeds

Presented without repair, per the prompt.

1. The thirty-one days. A man is beaten to death in a wharf car park; the only camera covering it belongs to an operator whose retention schedule deletes at thirty-one days; the body is not found until day thirty-three because of where it was left. Someone knew the schedule.

Decisive reason for rejection: Havenbay necessity. The premise is strong, the process is verified (UK ICO guidance points at roughly thirty to thirty-one days, and Australian practice commonly sits at thirty), the reconstruction is genuinely native to a merge board. But retention schedules are identical in every city on earth. Relocate it and nothing breaks, which is a Gate Seven failure. **Bankable for a later episode where Havenbay necessity is not the pilot's burden.**

2. The safety report. A dockworker is crushed by a container; the death is investigated by a contractor engaged by his own employer; the family is told he failed to follow a procedure that the maintenance record shows was impossible to follow.

Decisive reason: antagonist rationality, marginally. The cover-up is rational and cheap, which is good. The murder is not. Nothing in the premise requires anyone to have killed him, and once the death is genuinely accidental the episode is a negligence story rather than a murder-led pilot. Forcing a murder into it made the antagonist behave worse than the negligence already did.

3. The dredging permit. A harbour dredging programme is scheduled across a stretch of seabed where something was disposed of; the permit is signed by someone who knows.

Decisive reason: no living human cost inside the episode. It is a good season-arc mechanism and a poor pilot. The victim is historical, the keeper is absent, and the jeopardy is to evidence rather than to a person. It fails Gate Six.

4. The aged-care visit log. An elderly woman dies in a fall; her home-care provider's electronic visit-verification record places a carer in the house at the time; the record is later corrected.

Decisive reason: tonal and demographic collision. It is operationally excellent, the process is real and auditable, and the institution is self-protective rather than corrupt. But an elderly woman alone at home, betrayed by a carer, is structurally the pitch twelve testers already rejected, wearing a different hat. Distance from the known failure mode is a selection criterion, and this fails it.

5. The custody gap. A man dies in police custody; the custody record has a twenty-two minute gap and the cell camera was under maintenance.

Decisive reason: it makes the police the antagonist in episode one. Del is the series' proof that not all of Havenbay's police are compromised, and the bible reserves institutional-police corruption for later escalation. Spending it in the pilot burns the season's most valuable reversal and leaves Del nowhere to stand. Rejected on canon and structure, not plausibility.

1.4 Real-world processes researched for the survivors

Every claim below is **VERIFIED REAL-WORLD PROCESS** at a summary level from the sources listed. Havenbay's jurisdiction is not canonical, so per the prompt these are applied as a broadly shared operational baseline, not as a specific statute. Anything a premise depends on operationally is flagged where it still needs primary confirmation before script.

Process	Operative fact	Used by	Source
Forensic drift modelling of a body in water	Drift depends on currents, tides, waves and wind, and models are used forensically to estimate entry point. Critically: a shift of ±30 minutes in the assumed entry time produced a difference of tens of kilometres in modelled drift distance under strong tidal currents.	Slack Water	Australian Journal of Forensic Sciences, drift-tracking study
Misapplied forensic science in wrongful convictions	False or misleading forensic evidence is associated with a significant fraction of wrongful convictions	Slack Water	Journal of Forensic Sciences
Second or subsequent criminal appeal	Several Australian jurisdictions permit a further appeal where fresh and compelling evidence of a substantial miscarriage of justice emerges. South Australia enacted this as s353A in 2013, re-enacted as Criminal Procedure Act 1921 s159 in 2018. Where no such right exists, the route is a petition to government for referral back to the appeal court. Australia has no CCRC.	Slack Water	Adelaide Law Review , UNSW Law Journal
Coronial duty to identify	Formal identification of the deceased is a core coronial responsibility and forms a large part of death investigation in Australia	No Fixed Address	Forensic Science International
Why bodies remain unidentified	Absence of personal identification, condition of remains, and limited availability, quantity and quality of antemortem information	No Fixed Address	Forensic Science International , Unidentified decedent
Missing persons reporting	There is no waiting period in law. Departments may in practice ask for 24 to 72 hours where an adult's absence is believed voluntary, and should not for	No Fixed Address	FindLaw

Process	Operative fact	Used by	Source
	vulnerable persons or suspected foul play		
CCTV retention	UK ICO guidance points at no longer than 30 to 31 days; Australian practice commonly 30 days; footage capturing a crime may be retained past schedule once flagged	Rejected seed 1	Clearway , CCTV laws guide

NEEDS SOURCE before script, not before ruling: the precise mechanics of vessel position reporting in What the Log Says. The premise depends only on the shape of it, which is that certain commercial vessels transmit position automatically, that those transmissions are received and archived by third parties outside the operator's control, and that a gap in transmission is itself a recorded event. That shape is well established and safe to rule on. The specific carriage requirements, archive retention and evidentiary status must be confirmed before a script commits to a screenshot of a track.

1.5 Kill-gate table

Gate	Slack Water	What the Log Says	No Fixed Address
ZERO — operational reality	PASS	PASS	PASS , with the identification failure designed in rather than assumed
1 — immediate compulsion	UNKNOWN pending blind read	UNKNOWN pending blind read	UNKNOWN pending blind read
2 — two-track jeopardy	PASS (weaker track: the living target)	PASS (weaker track: Ally)	PASS (weaker track: Ally)
3 — medium-safe clock	PASS, day-stamped	PASS, day-stamped	PASS, day-stamped
4 — action-changing midpoint	PASS	PASS	PASS
5 — fair-play evidence	PASS	PASS	PASS
6 — human consequence	PASS	PASS	PASS
7 — Havenbay necessity	PASS, strongest in the field	PASS	PASS
8 — production reality	PASS	PASS	PASS
Agency and branch cost	PASS	PASS	PASS

Cold-open compulsion is UNKNOWN for all three and stays that way until blind testing. No candidate is advanced on the strength of a predicted pass.

PART TWO — ONE-PAGE PITCHES

SURVIVOR ONE — "Slack Water"

ELEVATOR PITCH: WHY THIS SHOULD BE THE GAME'S EPISODE ONE STORYLINE

Because it is the only premise in which Havenbay itself is the evidence. A young woman went into the harbour thirty years ago and washed up three kilometres up the reach, and a man went to prison largely because of where she was found. The tide that carried her is a measurable, documented, public thing, and thirty minutes either side of slack water moves a body kilometres. The prosecution's expert was confident and wrong. The man he helped convict has four months left to live. Somebody has been walking around this city for thirty years knowing exactly which half hour it was. Nothing about that story can be moved to another city, because the water is the witness, and the player's work is literally the reconstruction of a tide.

High concept. A wrongful conviction, overturned or not overturned by the player's investigation, in the last months of the convicted man's life, with the real killer still living quietly in Havenbay.

Opening promise. The record says one thing and the water says another, and one of them can be checked.

Player activity. Reconstructing a tide: tables, harbour logs, weather records, ferry timetables, the original trial exhibits and the drift model that was never run. Every merge builds a piece of the reconstruction that contradicts a sworn account.

Human engine. The convicted man never confessed and never protested loudly either, which Ally has to sit with. His daughter, who was eleven at the time and is now forty-one, gave evidence that helped convict him, and has believed for thirty years that she did the right thing.

Agency promise. Whether Ally publishes before the appeal, which risks prejudicing the very hearing she is trying to enable; whether she tells the daughter what her evidence actually did; and which of two irreconcilable expert routes she funds with the time she has.

Havenbay necessity. Absolute. The tidal reach, the ferry steps, the harbour's own records and thirty years of an obsolete gauge station are the case.

Strongest honest reservation. It is a cold case with a medical clock rather than a hunt. The canon says that is exactly what true crime is. The pivot asked for present-tense jeopardy. Those two things are in tension here and only Stephen can resolve it.

SURVIVOR TWO — "What the Log Says"

ELEVATOR PITCH: WHY THIS SHOULD BE THE GAME'S EPISODE ONE STORYLINE

Because it is the cheapest kind of evil to believe in, and therefore the most frightening. Nobody planned anything. A twenty-six-year-old deckhand was killed in a fight on a working boat, at night, by a man who did not mean to, and then a small company with port contracts and a safety record to protect typed him out of the night. Two versions of one page. His mother has the second one, framed, because it is the last document with

her son's name on it. There is no conspiracy, no mastermind and no coin. There is a form, and the people who signed it, and the fact that the vessel's own transmitted position proves the boat was nowhere near where the form says. The player rebuilds a voyage that a company would rather stayed unbuilt.

High concept. A death at sea, recorded as a man lost overboard, which the vessel's own automatic position record contradicts, exposing a cover-up performed not by criminals but by an ordinary business protecting its contracts.

Opening promise. A cleaner emptied a bin and found the same night written twice.

Player activity. Rebuilding one voyage from the fragments that outlive an operator's paperwork: transmitted position fragments received by third parties, fuel and tide, a crew roster, a harbour master's log, a mother's framed copy of the wrong page.

Human engine. The killer is not a monster; he is a crewmate who has been carrying it for five months and is the only person in the story who wants to be found. The mother wants the correct page. That is her entire request, and the episode is about whether a document can be an act of love.

Agency promise. Whether Ally protects the cleaner who tipped her off or uses what she gave; whether she goes to the regulator or to the company; and whether she gives the killer the chance to speak first or takes it from him.

Havenbay necessity. The port, the tide window that dictates when the vessel could have been where it was, and a waterfront economy where everyone's livelihood is downstream of the same three contracts.

Strongest honest reservation. The murder is unpremeditated, which is unusual for a pilot and may read as a smaller crime than the genre promises. The cover-up carries the weight, and a cover-up is a slower villain than a killer.

SURVIVOR THREE — "No Fixed Address"

ELEVATOR PITCH: WHY THIS SHOULD BE THE GAME'S EPISODE ONE STORYLINE

Because the murderer used a filing category as a weapon and it worked for eleven months. A woman was found under the viaduct last November and written down as unidentified female, no fixed address, death by misadventure. She had an address. She had a job. She had a mother who is still ringing a phone and telling herself her daughter is angry with her. The man who killed her did one cheap thing and one clever thing: he took her bag, and he chose where to leave her, because he knew what this city calls a woman it finds under a bridge. Giving her back her name is the whole episode, and it is the most satisfying ending the genre has, because the player earns a fact rather than a chase.

High concept. An unidentified woman is identified, eleven months late, and the identification is what convicts her killer, because the place he chose to leave her was the plan.

Opening promise. Three of the five things on her death record are wrong.

Player activity. Reconstructing a person from residue. A laundry tag, a library card with a different surname, a bus ticket, a mural photographed by someone else, a dental chart held in another jurisdiction that nobody ever asked for.

Human engine. Her mother, interstate, who did not report her missing because she believed the silence was anger. That belief is the thing the episode has to take off her, gently, and the player is the reason it becomes possible.

Agency promise. Whether Ally names her on air before her mother has been told; whether she pushes the coroner publicly or privately; and whether she trades the one piece of leverage she has for access she needs.

Havenbay necessity. The viaduct camps, the murals that function as a community's own records, the city's classification habits, and a redevelopment that is clearing the arches and taking the paint with it.

Strongest honest reservation. The victim is dead before the episode begins and stays dead, so the present-tense danger belongs to somebody else: a second woman, and the mother's exposure once the name is public. That is thinner than a hunt and it is the same reservation as Slack Water.

PART THREE — FULL PACKAGES

SURVIVOR ONE — "SLACK WATER"

A. Reality dossier

Verified baseline. Bodies in water drift under currents, tides, waves and wind, and drift models are used forensically to estimate where a body entered. The fragility that powers this episode is documented: in a published forensic drift study, **shifting the assumed entry time by half an hour changed the modelled drift distance by tens of kilometres** under strong tidal currents. A confident expert opinion about entry point is therefore only as good as its assumed entry time, and misapplied forensic science is associated with a substantial share of wrongful convictions.

First five causal events.

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
1	1996: a woman is killed at the ferry steps and goes into the water	The killer	None	Nobody	Body recovered days later, coronial referral	Investigation	None needed; he is not suspected	The body, the tide
2	Police build a case on where she came ashore	Detectives	Lawful investigation	Police hold exhibits	Retain an expert on drift	The expert's assumptions should be tested at trial	Not a bypass. An honest error nobody caught	The expert's report, still on the file
3	A man is convicted	Court	Judicial	Court record	Appeal within time	The first appeal happens and fails	None. The system worked as designed on bad inputs	Public transcript
4	Thirty years pass; the man is diagnosed as terminal	Prison health	Medical	Corrections	Palliative care, possible compassionate release application	None obstructing anyone	None needed	Medical records, his own consent to share
5	Ally re-runs the drift with modern data and the archived gauge record	Ally, with an oceanographer	None required; the inputs are public	Public	Fresh evidence is put to a lawyer, not to a newspaper	The court, which will not act on a podcast	No bypass. She must go through counsel	The new model, the archived tide record

Antagonist bypass. There is none, and that is the point. The killer never defeated a safeguard. He was never suspected, because somebody else was convicted. His entire method for thirty years has been *to do nothing*, which is why the least-cost test passes cleanly.

Professional objection, and the answer. A defence lawyer would say: fresh drift modelling is opinion, not fact, and courts are wary of re-litigating expert conclusions. Correct. Which is why the episode's proof cannot be the model alone. The model reopens the question; **the archived gauge record and one contemporaneous document place the killer at the steps in the half hour that matters.** The model is the door, not the answer.

Remaining non-foundational unknowns. Whether Havenbay has a statutory second-appeal right on fresh and compelling evidence, or only a petition-to-government referral route. Both exist in comparable jurisdictions. **PROPOSED CANON, requires Stephen's ruling**, and either works dramatically: the statutory route is cleaner, the petition route is slower and more humiliating and therefore better.

B. Identity

Title: Slack Water. **High concept:** the tide is the witness and it has been saying the same thing for thirty years. **Dramatic question:** if she could not have entered the water where they said, who was standing where she actually did? **Player fantasy:** you personally rebuild a piece of the physical world and it contradicts a court. **Exclusion statement:** no interrupted recording, no confession to a mentor, no hunted witness, no coded ritual, no staged drunken fall, no audio reconstruction to locate anybody. The reconstructive object is a tide, not a tape.

C. Blind cold open

ALLY (*on-mic*)

In the winter of nineteen ninety-six a young woman went into the harbour at the ferry steps. She was found four days later, three kilometres up the reach.

A man went to prison for it, mostly because of where she was found.

I have spent a month with the tide tables for that week. And here is the thing about tides that nobody told the jury.

Move the time she went in by half an hour, and she comes ashore kilometres from where she did. Half an hour. That is the whole margin.

The man they convicted has four months left. He has never once said he did it. That is not the same as being innocent, and I want to be careful about that.

But somebody has been walking around this city for thirty years knowing exactly which half hour it was.

D. Complete truth

Victim: a twenty-two-year-old ferry office clerk, 1996. **Killer:** the man who ran the ferry office's night float, who she had found taking money out of it. He met her at the steps to talk her out of reporting it, it went wrong, and it took ninety seconds. **Motive:** a small theft, not a big one. He has never stolen anything since. **Method:** a shove and the water. **Staging:** none. He did nothing clever at all, and that is why he was never caught. **Why now:** he is not active. He is a respectable man in his sixties who has been at every memorial. The threat is not that he acts; it is that he *does not have to*. **Decisive clue:** the ferry office's own float reconciliation sheet for that night, which he completed and signed at a time that puts him at the steps inside the half hour the corrected model requires. **Fair plant:** the sheet appears in phase one as background paperwork the player merges past, its timestamp visible and meaningless.

E. Human engine

Grievable detail: she had put a deposit on a flat that week and the receipt was in her coat. **Keeper:** the convicted man's daughter, forty-one, who as an eleven-year-old told police her father came home wet. **What the keeper wants:** not exoneration. She wants to know whether she lied. **What she does:** she has kept every document from the trial in a suitcase and has never opened it, and she opens it in phase two, herself, before Ally asks. **Warmth cost:** Ally spends a full visiting-day session with the convicted man during which he tells her nothing useful, and she does not record it.

F. Jeopardy and clock

Living target: the convicted man dies with the conviction standing, which is permanent. **Ally:** if she publishes before the appeal is decided, she risks prejudicing it and being blamed for the failure of the very thing she caused, which is the Teacher's Pet outcome exactly. Under Havenbay's all-party consent rule, publishing her prison recording is a separate offence. **Weaker track:** the living target, and it is still severe, because his window closes with or without her. **Closing window:** four months, day-stamped, pause-safe. **Central jeopardy sentence:** *a man has four months to stop being a murderer, and the only person who can prove he never was is the one who could also destroy the hearing by saying so out loud.*

G. Evidence chain

Obtained: archived tide gauge data, harbour records, trial transcript, the original expert's report, the ferry office paperwork. Interpretation: the entry time assumed at trial is unsupported. Verification: an independent oceanographer re-runs it, and Priya cross-checks the original report's method. Action: counsel files. **Wrong hypothesis:** Ally spends phase two convinced the original detective buried something, and he did not; he was simply given a confident expert and believed him. Ally says this on air and has to unsay it. **Midpoint recontextualisation:** the float sheet, already seen, becomes the clock. **Competent cast:** Priya reads the old report as a scientist, not a villain-hunter; Arthur has the Gazette's 1996 coverage and the reporter's notebook; Del cannot touch a closed conviction and says so, which is the constraint; Sabine Rourke supplies the only lawful route.

H. Havenbay engine

Indispensable: the tidal reach, the ferry steps, the harbour's obsolete gauge station, and a ferry office that no longer exists but whose paperwork went into the Gazette's archive when the company folded. **Causal fact:** the reach runs hard on the ebb and the drift window is genuinely half an hour wide. **Relocation test:** the case does not survive relocation at all. There is no version of this story inland.

I. Criminal economy

Who profits: nobody, and that is unusual and true. A man took a few hundred from a float. **Who does the dangerous work:** he did, once, for ninety seconds. **Which institution absorbs it:** the court, which accepted a confident expert; and the ferry company, which folded and whose records nobody read. **Who pays the ordinary cost:** a man's thirty years, and his daughter's belief about herself. **What compromises decent people:** an expert who was sure. **Season notch, PROPOSED CANON:** the ferry company's

records were bought at wind-up by a holding entity that also bought three other failed waterfront businesses that decade. One name recurs on the paperwork. Ally does not pursue it. Episode Two does.

J. Phase topology

Three phases, seventeen played leads, twenty-one authored.

Phase one, six leads. Entering question: could the tide have done what they said? Activity: assembling the tide, the transcript and the exhibits. Answer: no, not within the margin. Better question: then where did she enter, and who was there? Escalation: the appeal has a deadline the man may not meet. Payoff: the model runs, and it is wrong by kilometres.

Phase two, seven leads. Entering question: was this corruption or error? Activity: the 1996 investigation itself, the detective, the expert, the Gazette's coverage; the daughter opens the suitcase. Answer: error, and Ally was publicly wrong about that. Better question: if nobody hid anything, what did everybody simply not look at? Payoff: the float sheet resurfaces with a time on it.

Phase three, four leads. **Midpoint activity change:** the episode stops being a reconstruction and becomes a race to convert an argument into an admissible filing before a man dies. Activity: corroborating the float sheet, taking a statement, choosing what to publish. Payoff: the filing, and what it costs.

K. Agency

#	Decision Phase		Information	A	B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Reenter	Ending	Rejoin
1	Which expert route to fund with limited time	P1	Two credible methods, one fast and contestable, one slow and unassailable	Fast model	Slow reconstruction	Different lead set in P1, different requirement families, different evidence quality later	A	Speed or strength	The fast route is attacked at the hearing	Confidence of the finding	2 leads
2	Tell the daughter what her evidence did	P1 close	Ally knows; the daughter does not	Tell now	Wait for proof	TELL: she opens the suitcase early and a whole P2 lead is replaced by her testimony. WAIT: that lead is worked the hard way	A	Her trust, or her stability	Whether she will stand up at the hearing	Her closing scene	3 leads
3	Publish the wrong hypothesis correctly on air, or quietly	P2	Ally has accused a retired detective in public	Correct on air	Correct privately	ON AIR: costs subscribers, gains the detective's	B	Audience or access	He testifies, or does not	Who is in the room at the end	2 leads

#	Decision Phase		Information	on	B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Teater	Ending	Rejoin
						coopera tion and a P3 lead. PRIVA TE: keeps the audienc e, loses the detectiv e					
4	Air the case before the hearing	P3	Publish ing may prejudi ce it	Publish	Hold	PUBLI SH: three listener - sourced leads, subscri ber surge, and the hearing is stayed for months the man does not have. HOLD: slower, no surge, the hearing proceed s	C	The whole third phase differs	Ally's standin g, and a possibl e contem pt exposur e that persists	Which ending runs	3 leads
5	The prison recordi ng	P3 close	Recordi ng was lawful to make, unlawf ul to	Use it	Withho ld it	Zero VO. Using it strengt hens the filing	A	Strengt h of filing	Her exposur e	Epilogu e variant	at close

#	Decision Phase	Information	B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Teater	Ending	Rejoin
		broadca st		and creates a crimina l exposur e that Episode Two reads					

Four or more material decisions ✓ · at least two class A ✓ (three) · no more than one class C ✓ · no fork before rejoin ✓ · maximum divergence three leads ✓.

L. Ally, cast and art

Warmth costing her: the unrecorded visiting day. **Competence through action:** she finds the margin herself, in tide tables, before any expert is engaged. **Vulnerability:** she needs this man to be innocent, and says so. **Mistake with consequence:** the public accusation of the retired detective. **Irreversible change:** if she publishes, she carries a contempt exposure and the knowledge that she may have cost him his hearing.

Cast: Ally, Gerald (a serving detective in 1996 but at Brookford, another force, so he reads the file as a professional with no conflict, which is exactly his function), Arthur (Gazette archive), Priya (re-reads the original forensic report), Del (states the boundary: a closed conviction is not hers to touch), Sabine Rourke (the lawful route; **roster status proposed, no delivered portrait**), the Tip Line.

Portraits: Ally, Gerald, Del, Arthur, Priya, Tip Line existing or in progress. **New: Sabine Rourke** (proposed in roster, needs a sheet), the daughter (episode-level), the convicted man (episode-level, could be voice plus a photograph). The 1996 victim is a photograph only. **Cortez is not required, which saves the portrait both other candidates need.**

Locations: the ferry steps, a prison visiting room, the Gazette archive. Studio and diner reused.

M. Resolution and Episode Two handoff

The filing is made. Whether it succeeds, and whether he is alive for it, depends on decisions 2 and 4. The daughter learns she did not lie: she told the truth about a wet coat and adults built a conviction on it. **New season fact:** a holding entity bought the records of four failed waterfront businesses in the 1990s, and one name recurs. **New cost:** Ally's exposure, or her silence, depending on the branch. **What remains misunderstood:** she reads the purchases as asset-stripping. **Episode Two use:** they were not asset-stripping. They were record acquisitions. Somebody was buying what those companies knew. **PROPOSED CANON, requires ruling.**

N. Production reality

Lightest branching burden of the three. One class C branch. Four new portraits, of which one is a canon character already proposed. Two new locations plus one reused-with-dressing. Unusual UI: a tide reconstruction is the one genuinely new evidence interaction, and it is a chart, which is mobile-legible. Authored leads twenty-one against seventeen played. **Cannot be costed without economy data:** the tide-chart interaction, if it becomes bespoke rather than a dossier view.

O. Kill brief and verdict

Professional objection: an appellate lawyer says fresh expert opinion rarely reopens a conviction on its own. Answered: the model is the door, the float sheet is the proof.

Rational-antagonist objection: the killer has no reason to act at all, so there is no antagonist pressure. This is the real weakness and the honest answer is that the pressure comes from the clock and the court, not from a man. Accepted as a cost.

Ordinary-player objection: "this is a documentary, where is the danger." Real risk. Mitigation is the hearing clock and the fact that the player can lose the appeal.

Producer objection: the tide interaction could quietly become a bespoke feature.

VERDICT: PASS.

SURVIVOR TWO — "WHAT THE LOG SAYS"

A. Reality dossier

Verified baseline, in shape. Certain commercial vessels transmit their position automatically and continuously; those transmissions are received and archived by third parties entirely outside the operator's control; and a *gap* in transmission is itself a recorded event with a start and an end. A company can control its own paperwork. It cannot retrospectively control what other people's receivers already wrote down.

NEEDS SOURCE before script: carriage requirements, archive retention windows and evidentiary status of third-party position archives. The premise depends only on the shape above, which is safe to rule on. It must be confirmed before a script shows a track on screen.

First five causal events.

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
1	A fight on deck at night; a deckhand dies	A crewmate	None	The crew, at sea	Report immediately, return to port	Mandatory incident reporting	Not bypassed. Delayed. The skipper decides before dawn	The deck, the injury
2	The vessel diverts and the position transmitter is switched off for fifty minutes	The skipper	He controls his own equipment	Him	Nothing; equipment can fail	The gap is logged by every receiver in range	He believes silence leaves no record. He is wrong	A fifty-minute hole with a precise start and end
3	The death is reported as a man lost overboard, in a different position, later	The operator	They author their own incident report	Operator	Regulator receives it; coroner is notified	Investigation, and the family's questions	Plausible paperwork and a grieving family who accepts it	Two versions of one page, because the first was typed before the position was chosen
4	A coronial file opens and closes	Coroner	Statutory	Coroner	Findings on the material supplied	The coroner can only test what is in front of them	No bypass required; nobody contradicted the report	Public findings
5	A cleaner empties a bin eleven weeks later	A contract cleaner	None	Her, briefly	Nothing	None	None; this is luck, and it is the <i>inciting</i> luck, not the solving luck	Two pages

Institutional-power check. Nobody invents a power. The operator authors its own report, which companies do. The coroner tests what is supplied, which is the actual limit of coronial practice. The regulator is not corrupt, it is under-resourced and reads what it is sent. **The murder is not concealed by force. It is concealed by a form.**

Professional objection, and the answer. An investigator would say: a transmission gap proves nothing on its own, equipment fails constantly. Correct. The gap is not the proof. **The proof is that the operator's report states a position the vessel demonstrably held at a different hour, and that two internally inconsistent drafts exist.** The gap only tells you where to look.

B. Identity

Title: What the Log Says. **High concept:** a company typed a dead man out of a night, and the sea kept its own minutes. **Dramatic question:** why does one night exist twice on paper? **Player fantasy:** you rebuild a voyage nobody wanted rebuilt. **Exclusion statement:** no recording, no confession, no hunted person, no dead-man switch, no staged fall, and the victim is not the person who was investigating anything.

C. Blind cold open

ANNOUNCER (flat, synthetic): Message received: Tuesday, ten past six a.m.

A WOMAN (*tired, careful, reading something she has written down*): I clean the offices on the wharf. I am not going to say which one.

Last night I emptied a bin and there were two versions of the same page in it. Same night. Same boat. They do not say the same thing.

One of them has a man on board. The other one does not.

He drowned in March. His mother got the second one. She had it framed.

ALLY (*on-mic*): She left no name and no number, and she was right not to.

What she left was a date, a vessel, and the fact that somebody sat down and typed a dead man out of a night.

D. Complete truth

Victim: a twenty-six-year-old deckhand. **Killer:** a crewmate, thirty-one, in a fight about a stolen catch share. One push, one winch housing, ninety seconds. **Motive:** none worth the name. **Method:** unpremeditated. **Staging:** the skipper's, not the killer's, beginning about forty minutes later. **Why active now:** the killer is not active and has been trying to confess for five months in ways nobody notices. The *operator* is active, because the contract renewal is in six weeks and a fatality finding would end it. **Decisive clue:** the earlier draft's position, which corresponds to the vessel's real track, and which was changed only after the skipper checked a tide table. **Fair plant:** the mother's framed copy is shown in phase one, and the position on it is legible, and it means nothing yet.

E. Human engine

Grievable detail: he had bought his mother a phone with a bigger screen and set the text size himself so she could read it. **Keeper:** his mother. **What she wants:** the correct page. Not damages, not a prosecution. The right piece of paper. **What she does:** she has written to the operator eleven times, in longhand, and kept carbon copies, and the copies become evidence. **Warmth cost:** Ally spends the money and two days she needed elsewhere getting a certified copy for her, before the case requires it.

F. Jeopardy and clock

Living target: the cleaner, whose identity the operator is actively trying to determine and whose job and visa status are precarious. **Ally:** publishing a document a cleaner removed from a bin exposes both of them, and her source is not protected by anything except her own conduct. **Weaker track:** Ally, and it is genuine, because she can be sued and she can burn her only source. **Closing window:** six weeks to the contract renewal, after which the operator's incentive to lie disappears and so does its willingness to keep the papers. Day-stamped, pause-safe. **Central jeopardy sentence:** *a company has six weeks to keep a fatality out of its safety record, and the only person who can prove what happened cleans its offices at night.*

G. Evidence chain

Obtained: two drafts, the framed page, transmitted-position fragments, tide and fuel, crew roster, the mother's carbon copies. Interpretation: the reported position is impossible for the hour given. Verification: the position archive is third-party and Vega retrieves it; Cortez's findings on the injury do not match a fall. Action: the regulator and the coroner both have reopening routes. **Wrong hypothesis:** Ally believes the skipper killed him, and builds two leads on it, and is wrong; the skipper covered it up and did not do it, and that distinction matters to everyone. **Midpoint recontextualisation:** the framed page. **Competent cast:** Mo names the boat and the family within one conversation, because that is what the waterfront is; Cortez states what a winch injury is and is not; Del explains why a closed coronial finding needs a specific route; Vega gets the archive.

H. Havenbay engine

Indispensable: the port, the tide window that constrains where the vessel could have been at that hour, and a waterfront economy where three contracts feed everybody, so nobody talks. **Causal fact:** the tide dictates the vessel's possible positions and therefore breaks the report. **Relocation test:** it needs a working port with a tide and a small number of large contracts. Havenbay is that; a generic city is not.

I. Criminal economy

Profits: the operator, by keeping a clean safety record and a contract. **Dangerous work:** the skipper, who signed. **Institution that absorbs it:** an under-resourced regulator that reads what it is sent, and a coroner who can only test supplied material. **Ordinary cost:** a mother with the wrong page, and a crewmate who will carry it for life. **Compromise:** four men agreed at four in the morning that a fight would end all their jobs. **Season notch, PROPOSED CANON:** the operator's contracts were awarded under a harbour redevelopment tender. One of the two assessors on that panel also sat on another panel that matters later.

J. Phase topology

Two phases, sixteen played leads, twenty authored. The story genuinely resists a third phase, and the midpoint sits inside phase two.

Phase one, eight leads. Entering: why does one night exist twice? Activity: identifying the vessel, the night and the man; assembling the tide and the track. Answer: the reported position is impossible. Better question: who

chose the false one and why? Escalation: the operator starts looking for the cleaner. Payoff: the fifty-minute gap.

Phase two, eight leads. Entering: was this murder or a cover-up of an accident? **Midpoint activity change: the episode stops reconstructing a voyage and starts protecting a witness and racing a contract renewal** — the player's work turns from evidence to people. Answer: a fight, then four men and a form. Payoff: the correct page, and who is standing next to Ally when it is issued.

K. Agency

#	Decision Phase		Information		B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Later	Ending	Rejoin
1	Protect the cleaner or use what she gave	P1	Using it narrow s the operator's search to her shift	Use	Corroborate independently	USE: two leads faster, and a P2 lead spawns in which she is stood down. CORROBORATE: slower, higher requirements, she stays employed	A	Speed against a person	Whether she is available at the end	Her presence at the close	3 leads
2	Go to the regulator or to the company	P1 close	Regulator is slow and lawful; the company reacts	Regulator	Confront	REGULATOR: an official lead chain opens, slow, evidence-heavy. CONFRONT: the company moves, which produces evidence in its panic and	A	Order and safety of the whole second phase	What survives to the hearing	Which documents exist at the end	3 leads

#	Decision Phase		Information		B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Teater	Ending	Rejoin
						destroy s other evidenc e					
3	Correct the wrong hypothesis publicly	P2	Ally has implied the skipper is a killer	On air	Privately	ON AIR: subscriber cost, and the skipper talks. PRIV ATE: audienc e kept, skipper silent	B	Audience or the only insider	Whether the killer is reached through him	Who confesses and how	2 leads
4	Give the killer the chance to come forward first	P2	He has been trying to be caught	Approach him	Publish and let it land on him	APPROACH: a class C exclusive chain, he speaks, and the mother gets an apology as well as a page. PUBLISH: he is arrested cold, the mother gets the page and nothing else	C	Three leads differ	His plea, and what the mother is given	Two materially different endings	3 leads
5	The mother's carbon copies	P2	They are hers, and using	Use	Keep her out	Zero VO. Change s evidenc	A	Proof strengthening	Her standing	Epilogue variant	at close

#	Decision Phase	Information	B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Reater	Ending	Rejoin
		them		e					
		exposes		quality					
		her		and					
				whethe					
				r she					
				appears					
				in the					
				final					
				lead					

Gates satisfied: four or more ✓ · at least two class A ✓ (three) · one class C ✓ · rejoin within three ✓.

L. Ally, cast and art

Warmth: the certified copy, paid for and fetched before it was useful. **Competence:** she identifies the vessel from the page's header format before anyone tells her. **Vulnerability:** she wants this to be a conspiracy, because a conspiracy is a better episode, and it is not one. **Mistake:** the skipper accusation. **Irreversible change:** she learns that the story she wanted was worse than the story that was true, and says so on air.

Cast: Ally, Mo (waterfront, and this is her best use in the series so far), Del, Cortez (cause of death; **proposed, portrait required**), Vega (position archive), the Tip Line, Gerald in a light advisory role. **New:** the mother, the skipper, the crewmate, the cleaner (voice only, and she must stay voice only). **Locations:** a working wharf office, a boat deck at night, the mother's flat.

M. Resolution and Episode Two handoff

The finding is reopened, the correct page is issued, and depending on decision 4 the crewmate either speaks or is taken. The operator loses the contract, which is not justice and is what actually happens. **New fact:** the contract was awarded under a redevelopment tender with a two-person assessment panel. **New cost:** Ally's source loses her job in most branches, and Ally knows it. **Misunderstood:** Ally reads the panel as ordinary procurement. **Episode Two use:** one assessor's name recurs where it should not. **PROPOSED CANON.**

N. Production reality

Middle burden. One class C. Four new episode-level characters, one of whom is voice only. Cortez portrait required. Two or three new locations, one of which is a night deck and is the most expensive image in the pack. Sixteen played, twenty authored.

O. Kill brief and verdict

Professional: a transmission gap proves nothing. Answered: the gap indicates, the inconsistent drafts prove.

Rational antagonist: why keep both drafts? Answered, and it must be shown: the earlier draft was printed for signature and the signature never happened, so it went in a bin instead of a shredder because a shredder

was two floors up. That is how documents actually survive, and it must be depicted or the whole premise is luck.

Ordinary player: "would a company really do that." Yes, and the audience will believe it faster than they will believe a mastermind.

Producer: the night-deck location is the one real art risk.

VERDICT: PASS.

SURVIVOR THREE — "NO FIXED ADDRESS"

A. Reality dossier

Verified baseline. Formal identification of the deceased is a core coronial responsibility and a large component of death investigation. Bodies nonetheless remain unidentified, and the documented causes are the absence of personal identification, the condition of the remains, and **limited availability, quantity and quality of antemortem information**. Identification runs on fingerprints where prints are on file, dental comparison where a chart is requested from the right practice, and DNA where a family reference sample exists to compare against. Every one of those requires somebody, somewhere, to connect two records.

Separately: **there is no legal waiting period to report a person missing.** Departments may in practice ask for twenty-four to seventy-two hours where an adult's absence is believed voluntary, and should not where the person is vulnerable or foul play is suspected.

This is the whole premise, and it is not a loophole. Nobody in this story fails at their job. The coroner discharges the identification duty with the material available: no prints on file, no dental chart requested because no practice is known, no family reference sample because no family has come forward, no missing-person report to match against because the one person who would have made it believes the silence is a choice.

First five causal events.

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
1	A man kills a woman he knows, in the arches under the viaduct	The killer	None	Him, briefly	Investigation once found	Identification would lead straight to him	He takes her bag. That is the entire bypass and it costs him nothing	Her body, the place
2	She is found and recorded as unidentified	Police, then coroner	Statutory	Coroner	Full identification effort	The duty to identify	Not bypassed. Discharged, and it fails on absent antemortem data	The file, and everything in it
3	No missing-person report is ever made	Her mother, interstate	Hers	Nobody	A report would create a match	The reporting system	No bypass. She believes her daughter is angry with her	Eleven months of unanswered calls
4	Death is recorded as misadventure	Coroner	Statutory	Coroner	Findings on available material	Post-mortem	Not bypassed. The injury is consistent with a fall, and there was nobody to say she had no reason to be there	The findings, which are public
5	Ally is given the file number	A community worker	None	Her	Nothing	None	None needed	The number

Institutional-power check. No institution lacks a power it has. No professional is absent, slow or incurious. The coroner does the job correctly and the job produces the wrong answer because of what was never supplied. **That is the most defensible antagonist in the entire field: not a corrupt system, a correct one running on an empty input.**

Antagonist least-cost. He took a bag. That is the cheapest possible concealment and the most effective, and he chose the location because he understood, correctly, what a body under the viaduct gets recorded as. He

has done nothing since and needs to do nothing. He is not a mastermind; he is a man who guessed right about paperwork.

The identification failure, designed rather than assumed. She had been in Havenbay four months, having left interstate after a fallout. Cash-in-hand work, sublet room, no lease in her name. Prints not on file. Her dental records exist in another state and are never requested because no practice is known. Her mother does not report her missing, because their last conversation was a bad one and silence is what she is expecting. **PASS with this designed in, and if it is ever removed the premise fails.**

Remaining non-foundational unknowns: how long an unidentified deceased is held before disposition in Havenbay, and whether an exhumation would be needed for a later comparison. Affects one lead in phase three. **NEEDS SOURCE before script.**

B. Identity

Title: No Fixed Address. **High concept:** the classification was the murder weapon. **Dramatic question:** who was she, and who knew the answer to that question was worth taking? **Player fantasy:** you give a woman her name back and the name convicts a man. **Exclusion statement:** no recording, no confession, no hunted witness, no coded ritual, no staged drowning, no audio location work. The reconstructive object is a person's identity assembled from residue.

C. Blind cold open

ALLY (*on-mic*)

The file number is the only name she has.

A woman was found under the viaduct last November, and the record says: unidentified female, thirty to forty-five, no fixed address, death by misadventure.

Three of those five things are wrong.

She had an address. She had a job. And she has a mother who is still ringing a phone that stopped being answered in November, and telling herself her daughter is angry with her.

Whoever killed her did one cheap thing and one clever thing.

The cheap thing was taking her bag.

The clever thing was choosing where to leave her. Because he knew exactly what this city writes down when it finds a woman under a bridge.

D. Complete truth

Victim: thirty-four, four months in Havenbay, working cash-in-hand in a laundry and sleeping in a sublet room off the arches. **Killer:** the man who sublet her the room, who had been taking money from her and was about to be reported to the agency that placed her. **Motive:** small, ugly and financial. **Method:** a shove onto a stone stair, unpremeditated, followed by a decision that was entirely premeditated. **Staging:** he moved her forty metres to the arches, and took her bag, keys and phone. **Why now:** he is not active as a killer. He is active as a landlord, and there is another woman in that room. **Decisive clue:** a laundry tag with a machine number, which ties her to a workplace, which produces a wage book with no surname and a mobile number

that reaches a disconnected service whose last cell registration is not the arches. **Fair plant:** the tag is visible in the coronial property list in phase one, one line among thirty, and means nothing until phase two.

E. Human engine

Grievable detail: she had been paying a fortnightly instalment on a second-hand keyboard and had three payments left, and the shop kept the layby card with her first name on it. **Keeper:** her mother, interstate, who has been composing and deleting the same message since December. **What she wants:** initially, to be left alone; she does not want to be told that her anger was misplaced. **What she does:** she supplies the dental practice's name, which is the single piece of information nobody in Havenbay could ever have found, and she does it herself, on a phone call she initiates. **Warmth cost:** Ally flies interstate on her own money and does not record the conversation, and comes back with nothing that day.

F. Jeopardy and clock

Living target: the woman currently renting the same room from the same man. **Ally:** naming a murder victim on air before her family has been notified is the single most damaging thing a true-crime podcaster can do, and it is entirely within her power to do it by accident. Under the all-party rule, the recordings she gathers in the laundry are lawful only if she asks, and she is working with people who cannot afford to say no.

Weaker track: Ally, because her exposure is ethical and professional rather than physical, and it is real.

Closing window: the arches are being cleared for redevelopment in five weeks, and with them the murals, the sublet rooms and every person who remembers her. Day-stamped, pause-safe. **Central jeopardy**

sentence: *a woman has been dead for eleven months without a name, the only people who remember her face are being moved on in five weeks, and the man who killed her is still letting that room.*

G. Evidence chain

Obtained: the coronial property list, a laundry tag, a wage book, a layby card, a mural photograph, a disconnected number's last registration, and finally a dental chart from interstate. Interpretation: she was not transient and not where she was found. Verification: dental comparison confirms identity; Cortez revisits the injury with a known height and a known stair. Action: the coroner reopens; Del can now act, because an identified woman with a landlord dispute is a case and an unidentified woman was a category. **Wrong hypothesis:** Ally is certain for two leads that this is a redevelopment story, that she was cleared out and it went wrong, and she says so publicly. It is not. It is one man and a rent book. **Midpoint recontextualisation:** the laundry tag. **Competent cast:** Cortez cannot identify her without antemortem data and says so plainly, which is the constraint the whole episode turns on; Del explains exactly why a category is not a case; Nova Skye's murals are the community's own record and the only photograph of her face that exists; Arthur has the redevelopment paperwork.

H. Havenbay engine

Indispensable: the Stonebridge Viaduct arches, the camps beneath them, the murals that function as a neighbourhood's memory, and a redevelopment clearing all three. **Causal fact:** the city's own classification habit, which is what the killer exploited, plus a mural painted from life that is the only surviving image of her.

Relocation test: the classification exists everywhere, but the mural, the arches and the five-week clearance are specifically Havenbay, and the case cannot be proved without the mural.

I. Criminal economy

Profits: a man skimming rent from people who cannot complain. **Dangerous work:** he did it himself, once. **Institution that absorbs it:** none corruptly. A coroner without inputs, a police service that cannot open a case on a category, and a placement agency that does not check who it places people with. **Ordinary cost:** eleven months in which a mother believed her daughter hated her. **Compromise:** everyone who knew her was in a position where being noticed by an institution was more dangerous than staying quiet. **Season notch, PROPOSED CANON:** the arches clearance is being run by a private contractor engaged by the redevelopment, and the contractor is instructed to photograph and remove the murals rather than paint over them. Somebody is collecting them. Ally notes it and moves on.

J. Phase topology

Three phases, eighteen played leads, twenty-three authored.

Phase one, six leads. Entering: who is the woman behind a file number? Activity: the coronial file, the property list, the arches, the first witnesses. Answer: she was not transient. Better question: if she had a life, why did nobody miss her? Payoff: the wage book, and a first name.

Phase two, seven leads. Entering: whose life was it? Activity: the laundry, the layby, the mural, the disconnected number, the interstate call. Answer: a name, and a dental chart on its way. **Ally is publicly wrong about the redevelopment here.** Payoff: identification.

Phase three, five leads. **Midpoint activity change: the moment she has a name, the episode stops being an identification and becomes a prosecution,** and the player switches from assembling a person to assembling a case, and to getting a woman out of a room. Payoff: the reopened finding and the arrest.

K. Agency

#	Decision Phase		Information		B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Center	Ending	Rejoin
1	Broadcast the file number and appeal for anyone who knew her	P1	Nobody knows her name; the camps distrust attention	Broadcast	Work it door to door	BROADCAST: two listener - sourced leads, and the camps close to her, raising requirements on three later leads. DOOR TO DOOR: slow, expensive in energy, and everyone talks	A	Reach against trust	Whether witness appears at the end	Who stands with her at the close	3 leads
2	The mural: photograph it or get it removed and preserved	P2	Clearance is in five weeks	Photograph	Preserve	PHOTOGRAPH: free and fast, and the image is contested later. PRESERVE: costs a whole lead and a favour, and it is	A	Time against evidential weight	Whether the identification is challenged	Whether the mural survives the clearance	2 leads

#	Decision Phase		Information		B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Feater	Ending	Rejoin
						unimpeachable evidence					
3	Name her on air once identified, before the mother is ready	P2 close	Ally has the name; the mother has asked for a day	Name her	Wait	NAME: the case accelerates, a P3 lead spawns from public response, and the mother hears it from a stranger. WAIT: one day lost, and the mother appears in the final lead	B	Speed against a person	Whether the mother participates	The closing scene	2 leads
4	The other woman in the room	P3	Warning her may alert him	Warn her now	Wait for the arrest	WARN: exclusive chain in which she is moved and he notices, and the arrest becomes a race. WAIT: cleaner arrest, and Ally carries having	C	Three leads differ	What Ally has to live with	Two materially different endings	3 leads

#	Decision Phase		Information		B	Play change	Class	Immediate	Rejoinder	Ending	Rejoin
						left her there					
5	The laundry recordings	P3	Workers cannot afford to refuse	Use them	Ask again and lose some	Zero VO. Change the evidence quality and which witnesses stand	A	Proof against consent	Who testifies	Epilogue variant	at close

Gates satisfied: four or more ✓ · at least two class A ✓ (three) · one class C ✓ · rejoin within three ✓.

L. Ally, cast and art

Warmth: the unrecorded interstate visit, paid for herself, returning with nothing that day. **Competence:** she reads the property list and sees the laundry tag, which thirty people have read past. **Vulnerability:** she wants this to be about the redevelopment, because that is the story she believes about her city, and it is not. **Mistake:** she says so publicly and is wrong. **Irreversible change:** if she names her early, she has done to a mother exactly what the genre is accused of doing to families, and she knows it.

Cast: Ally, Del (why a category is not a case), Cortez (**proposed, portrait required**; his constraint is the episode's engine), Nova Skye (**roster canon, portrait status proposed**; the murals and the community's trust), Arthur (redemption paperwork), Helen (one scene, on what a mother assumes about silence), Mo, the Tip Line. **New:** the victim (photograph and mural only), the mother, the landlord, the woman in the room.

Locations: the viaduct arches, a commercial laundry, an interstate kitchen. The arches are a significant new environment and the mural is a bespoke art asset that must be good, because the plot rests on it.

M. Resolution and Episode Two handoff

She is identified, the finding is reopened, the landlord is charged. The mother comes to Havenbay and stands under the arch. Whether the mural is still there depends on decision 2. **New fact:** the clearance contractor is photographing and removing murals rather than painting over them, on instruction. **New cost:** the camps are gone and the people who remembered her are dispersed, which the player caused partly by drawing attention. **Misunderstood:** Ally reads the mural removal as heritage or vandalism-management. **Episode Two use:** somebody is collecting the murals because one of them recorded something. **PROPOSED CANON.**

N. Production reality

Heaviest of the three. Two proposed-portrait canon characters required (Cortez, Nova Skye), four episode-level characters, three new locations of which the arches are substantial, and one bespoke mural asset with plot weight. Eighteen played, twenty-three authored. **Cannot be costed without production data:** the mural, which is a hero asset rather than a background.

O. Kill brief and verdict

Professional objection: a coroner would identify her. Answered in full: identification requires antemortem data, and the designed absence of every channel is the premise. If a script ever softens that, the episode fails.

Rational antagonist: why not simply dispose of her properly? Because moving a body is the riskiest thing he could do, and forty metres to a place that reclassifies her is cheaper and worked for eleven months.

Ordinary player: "would nobody really report her missing?" This is the objection that will land, and the answer must be dramatised early through the mother rather than explained. It is also the truest thing in the pack.

Producer: the mural is a hero asset carrying plot weight, and the arches are a new environment.

VERDICT: PASS.

PART FOUR — RANKING AND SLATE DECISION

4.1 Intrinsic forced ranking, no incumbent comparison

Dimension	1st	2nd	3rd
Predicted cold-open compulsion (UNKNOWN, prediction only)	No Fixed Address	Slack Water	What the Log Says
Victim or keeper jeopardy	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says	Slack Water
Ally jeopardy	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says	Slack Water
Clock compatibility	What the Log Says	No Fixed Address	Slack Water
Midpoint activity transformation	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says	Slack Water
Connelly evidence chain	Slack Water	What the Log Says	No Fixed Address
Harper Havenbay necessity	Slack Water	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says
Hallett medium integration	Slack Water	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says
Lehane criminal economy	What the Log Says	No Fixed Address	Slack Water
Meaningful agency	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says	Slack Water
Affordability of that agency	Slack Water	What the Log Says	No Fixed Address
Emotional keeper	No Fixed Address	What the Log Says	Slack Water
Production feasibility	Slack Water	What the Log Says	No Fixed Address

4.2 Overall ranking

1. No Fixed Address · 2. What the Log Says · 3. Slack Water.

No Fixed Address wins despite Slack Water holding the strongest advantage in the field, which is that the tide is the most Havenbay-necessary and most reconstructive evidence anyone has proposed for this project. It loses anyway because Slack Water has no antagonist pressure at all: its villain's correct strategy is to keep doing nothing, so the tension is entirely institutional and medical. No Fixed Address has the same reconstructive spine, a keeper whose need is devastating and specific, a midpoint that genuinely changes the player's task from assembling a person to assembling a case, and a killer who is still letting that room.

4.3 Forced cut

Cut: Slack Water.

Not on quality. On the single decisive reason that its antagonist never has to act, so the episode's only pressure is a clock nobody controls and a court that cannot be hurried. In a pilot, whose job is to make a stranger need the next part, an antagonist with no reason to move is a structural liability rather than a subtlety. It should be banked, because as a mid-season episode, played to an audience that already trusts the show, it would be superb.

4.4 Comparison with the incumbents

Using only the pivot-brief summaries and the supplied occupied-territory list, and noting that the incumbents have since been through Kill Gate Zero with **G conditional pass, H fail, I fail**.

No Fixed Address most directly challenges I, "The Last Caller." Both are about a woman nobody is looking for. I does it with a hunted living witness and an antagonist who must behave irrationally to permit a confession. No Fixed Address does it with a woman already dead and an antagonist whose one clever act is choosing a filing category. **It improves on I** by removing the rationality failure entirely and by giving the search a physical, reconstructive object. **I may still do one thing better:** its cold open is more immediately arresting, because a hand over a receiver is an event and a file number is a fact.

What the Log Says most directly challenges H, "The Overnight Girl." Both are harbour-economy stories with an ordinary person killed for a small reason. **It improves on H** decisively on antagonist rationality, which is precisely where H failed: nobody tours a trust network, nobody stores a body absurdly, and the cover-up is done by people whose least-cost action genuinely is to lie on a form. **H may still do one thing better:** Nina is a more compelling living protagonist than a grieving mother, and H's accumulating ending remains the best agency design produced for this project.

Neither challenges G, "The Confession," which occupies different ground and is the only incumbent still standing.

4.5 Recommendation

Recommend exactly one new candidate for the table-read: No Fixed Address.

The slate for a blind comparative read then becomes **G, "The Confession"** (repaired per the audit) and **No Fixed Address**. Two premises, not three, which is the honest consequence of two incumbents failing and only one challenger earning a place.

If Stephen wants three, **What the Log Says is the third**, and it is a genuine pass rather than a quota filler. I am not recommending it above No Fixed Address only because two harbour-industry stories would be adjacent, and the read discriminates better when the options are further apart.

4.6 The strongest case against my own recommendation

No Fixed Address opens on a fact rather than an event. A file number is an idea, and ideas are harder to hear at listening speed than a hand coming over a receiver or a boy reciting a phone code. It is entirely possible that a blind read shows it is admired and not craved, which is the worst result a pilot can get. Its second weakness compounds this: the victim is dead before it begins and never in danger, so the compulsion rests entirely on wanting to know who she was. That is exactly what the canon says works, and this project has no evidence that it works for *this* audience on *this* platform.

And it is the most expensive of the three to build, with two proposed portraits, a new environment and a hero art asset the plot depends on, at a moment when the schedule is under pressure.

4.7 Evidence that should overturn this

A blind read in which No Fixed Address is not chosen first by a plurality. A ruling that the pilot's present-tense jeopardy requirement is strict, in which case all three of these are weaker than a hunt and the exercise should be rerun with that as a hard gate. Or a production ruling that no new portraits can be commissioned, which promotes Slack Water, since it is the only candidate that does not need Cortez.

4.8 Fact, inference, proposal, unknown

Fact: the researched processes in Part One, sourced. The incumbents' Gate Zero results. **Inference:** every ranking in 4.1, and the reading of what testers meant. **Proposal:** all three premises, every season notch, and the two-appeal-route question, all marked PROPOSED CANON and requiring rulings. **Unknown:** cold-open compulsion for all three, which no internal process can resolve.

4.9 Execution record

Field	Value
Execution ID	EX-2026-08-24-01
Model and mode	Claude Opus 5, extended reasoning, web research available
Source versions	pivot brief 2026-08-23 incl. 08-24 rulings · charter 2026-08-23 · VO lock v1.1 · bible incl. §2.3.1 · roster incl. Del adds · portrait prompts
Seed field	26 in field one; no second field
Gate Zero attrition	14 rejected at Gate Zero; 9 rejected pre-research; 3 survived
Final survivors	Slack Water · What the Log Says · No Fixed Address
Table-read recommendation	No Fixed Address
Owner disposition	<i>pending</i>